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Mary Douglas

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2003

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

UK Data Archive, University of Essex, Colchester. June 2017

SN 6226 - Pioneers of Social Research, 1996-2012. Depositor: Thompson, P.
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Professor Mary Douglas
Interviewed by Paul Thompson
6 August 2003

1. Early family influences: parents and grandparents

(p.1)
I was born in 1921. My mother was 21, and my father was in his early thirties, so there's a big gap… he was in the Indian Civil Service in Burma, and in those days, the Civil Servants got very highly-paid, and they got one very long leave every three years, and short leaves of one month, called "local leaves", every year. So luckily, I was born on the occasion of one of the long leaves…

He joined in 1907. He'd been to Cambridge before that, and done a degree in Classics. He was the only member of my family who had ever been to university – on that side. He didn't know what to do, after Classics. He didn't get a brilliant degree, so that he didn't have to think he must teach and study Classics. He liked it a lot, it meant a lot to him, but he really, his whole choice was governed by his love of trout fishing, and he looked at various maps to see where he could have a career that would give him the best fishing!

(p.2)
[My father] stayed in Burma till '33. I was brought up there. My first five years, yes……. We had Burmese ayahs - but that's not a Burmese word - but it meant a nanny, otherwise all the house servants were not Burmese, they were mostly Indian – Hindus. But they were very sweet, I think. And that's the level of memories, of being in a park together with other children - and photographs.

(p.5)
My grandfather was also in the Indian Civil Service, in the judicial side, in the judiciary. So he went out much earlier, it must have been after the end of the Third Burmese War, and he became a judge. He's an Irishman. And I think he was quite popular as a wild Irishman…from a happy-go-lucky family in Ireland..

(p.3-4)

When I was five, it was regarded as the age at which you had to come home. Complete fiction, I think. It's an amazing idea, that the children had to be separated from their mothers. The mothers had to stay with the fathers, because they couldn't trust them, probably, to stay on their own – a question of fidelity, probably. But they sent all their children home. I know lots of others who have had this destiny in store for them. But the hard thing was, I reached five, and because they thought I would be lonely at home with my grandparents, they sent my sister, who was only three. It was terribly hard for her…

Would you say that you were close to your mother or father, then?

We couldn't be! (LAUGHS) We were two thousand miles away, or whatever it is!

(LAUGHS) But you had those first years, and then did you not see them for holidays?

Not very much in the first years either. I can't remember them tremendously well in the first years. I remember my father much better, because when my mother died, he looked after us and brought us up, and then, of course, he revived all the memories by talking about it a lot.

Oh, so how old were you when she died, then?

Twelve. He retired in order to devote himself to us, you see. And he was 50. He'd had 25 years of that awful climate, and he was absolutely riddled with malaria and things, so he had to retire really.

And again, was that very painful, your mother dying?

Yes. Don't talk about it…

(p.4)

[My father] was a very a literary person, and he made us read all his childhood books, so again, we read *Captains Courageous*, and all the Henty books, and all the W.W. Jacob

books. As we grew older, we read all the books he liked as a boy. But he also liked to talk about Horace, and Greek and Latin, and he was organising plays for the Drama Society, which he actually founded in Marlow, Bucks., so that we read all the one-act plays he could [find] in the house, and then he loved, at table, he loved to discuss origins of words. (LAUGHS)…. And he was always writing for *Punch*, or about fishing. He was publishing little essays, and I have about 25 of them, about fishing.

(p.5-6)
[My maternal grandmother] comes from a very constricted family…. – as a clergyman's daughter. He'd planned to open a Dame's School, but he planned that his eldest daughter – my grandmother – would be the Dame to the Dame's School, and he would retire on the proceeds of this. But she didn't fancy that. But he had had her educated with the boys, so she learnt Latin and Greek and all there was, really, to learn, but she learnt it with her brothers, had books thrown at her head like they did - very egalitarian - for not remembering her conjugations of verbs! And so she was educated, unusually. But she ran away from home to become a nurse. And that was very daring. She was a very strong character, but very suppressed and anxious, and I think socially anxious.

(p.6-7)
Do you think they were an influence on you in any way? Your grandparents?

Her a lot, yes. Yes. When she was retired and living in Devonshire, with us, they nobly took us on for seven years you see. Not many grandmothers could do that….

This is your father's mother?

My mother's mother. My grandfather was in Burma, as well as my father, so it was my mother's mother. She used to run the Women's Institute with the other women, and she used to be a judge of apple jam, and apple jelly, and she used to keep bees, and she used to have bridge parties to raise money for something or other, and it was always a sort of tremendous anxiety at the local bridge parties. "Oh, I know it's going to be a fiasco!" "What's a fiasco, Granny?" (LAUGHS) You remember these words, you know! So I knew she was anxious. Yes. She was a bit formal with us….We really didn't talk at all, no. Really didn't. No… We never had anybody cursing or swearing, or any discussions

of money at all! No! We really didn't know what was happening in the world at all! (LAUGHS).

2. Religion

(p.7-8)
And what about religion?

Good question! My grandfather, being Irish, my mother was Catholic as well as he, and in those days, she made a promise to bring up the children as Catholics. And my father didn't mind which way they were brought up. But he, himself, was a strong agnostic – if you can say that! He didn't quite disbelieve in God, but as near as possible, he just kept saying, "Well, how does one know?" And so he had no religion, in effect. … No, he never talked about religion, ever. No. So we were sent to this Convent School.

(p.8)
My grandmother, who was a stout Protestant, who brought us up, took her duty terribly seriously, and she thought it was her duty to bring us up as Catholics, and so she taught us our Catholic catechism… But it didn't make much impact on us. I don't remember any of that, but I heard about it afterwards. I don't remember it. She took us to school, she took us to Sunday School. And she took us to Mass every Sunday, but then my grandfather went to Mass every Sunday.

Schools

(pp.9-11)
The schools were terribly important. The first school was called Studley Knowle in Torquay, and the nuns were a little French Order, recruiting Catholic nuns from Ireland, so it was French and Irish. And at that time, as you might know from social reading, there was a very strong, as it were, sectarian attitude in the Catholic Church, you were inside or you were out, and Heaven was only inhabited by Catholics and the rest had to look out for themselves! …. But I loved the School, I really enjoyed it very very much. And obviously I was very well taught.

When I left at 12, when my mother died, before she died, she handed us over to the school that she had been at, which was in London – Roehampton… And I was well educated for that school by that time, you know, I'd had a good start. That wasn't an academic school in any sense, much less, really, than the little Irish/French ones on the other side…the nuns really despised the world, and the examination system was one of the worldly things that one shouldn't be bothering about too much. But they did it because they got a grant for coming up to certain academic standards, in those days – educational standards – quite a big grant, it was important for them. So we were prepared for exams, but they weren't terribly important compared with singing, music and practically nothing else, really! Religion. Doctrine was terribly important, mmm. And they so loved teaching us theology that we enjoyed it very much. All the children did.

It's a Jesuit education, actually.. All my life I've continued to come across the problems they talked about and find that they really were very far ahead on the theological solutions to enigmas and mysteries and problems. And we did get the subtle theological - the casuistry, which is so important, I think.

So do you think, in terms of sort of developing your intellectual interest, that was important?

Oh, crucial. Absolutely crucial. Yes. Yeah. I know that the doctrine was, because of all the metaphysical questions it opened up for one, and ways of talking about them too. But the strong confidence of faith, because they had warned you against what belief meant, and what unbelief meant, you didn't have to bother too much, you know. Oh, we were very much warned against "scrupulosity" and other sorts of wonderful words like that, like, have you ever heard of "human respect"? You've never heard of it? (LAUGHS)

Not in that way, no!

No. Human respect is an ethical failing. It means doing things because you think they're required of you, not being inner-directed, but doing it because you think it's expected of you, respecting other humans! (LAUGHS) And they had lots of little private words like that, belonging to the School. About doctrine, I was going to say something then. I really

loved the orderliness of the life, and I loved the hierarchical protections that they provided for each other, against each other.

3. Structures: Certainty, order and hierarchy

(p.49)

I think this experience of complete confidence and certainty about everything, and the future, and about what were they to eat on Tuesday, and what you're going to eat on Wednesday, everything absolutely laid out, was very comforting and good for children who had lost their mother, who were away from their parents. My mother was alive, but she wasn't with us. But it completely unfits you for social life in modern England, anyway! So that when we went to school, again, it was a hierarchy. At the first Convent School, and then the second Convent School, the same thing, Mondays and Tuesdays, you knew what you were going to eat, you knew what time to get up, you knew what were the exceptions, and then you had holidays which broke all the rules, so there were rules that were made to be broken on the holidays. What could a holiday be, except by breaking the rules? And you learnt a lot about formal aspects of co-ordination, social relations.

But when I got to Oxford, none of it worked, and I felt very isolated, lonely, and shy, outside school. Very confident in school, and very shy, inarticulate when I left. It doesn't fit you for life! (LAUGHS) But it did make a tremendous - in a sense, I've been looking for it ever since - a real hierarchy, in which the top respects the bottom, because they depend on it, this hierarchical structure which you have not just a voice going down, giving the commands, but in which that voice is harkening to what the people are wanting below, because they won't stand if they don't say it…. Once we heard a nun chastising another nun in front of us once. We were all shocked. The abuse of authority, not backing her subordinate, in front of the girls! We were shocked. This respect for seniority and juniority – mutual respect – was something which I'm looking for always.

4. Oxford University

(pp.14-15)

MD: I would have liked to have gone to the LSE and done sociology, but I didn't know about universities, or about the LSE, and the nuns did. They said, "You can't go to the LSE, it's a Godless place. You'll lose your faith there!" (LAUGHS) Also it would be Communist, which was dreaded, much dreaded by the Catholics at that time.

So they were all very good at history, and I was hopeless at history. I didn't want to do it either. I wanted to do this analytical thing. So they looked up and found there was this thing called PPE, and I was delighted, and went and did that. But it was much too difficult for me. I hadn't nearly prepared….

It was the War, so that anybody who was at all active, was called up. It was 1940. And it was a bad time to be up. And the students weren't there either, very much, it was a rather empty place, and quite hard to keep studying really well. I didn't really work very hard. I didn't know how to work, really. I got a medium kind of degree, a class II.

5. Civil Service and Anthropology

(pp.16-17, 18)
Well, the War was on, so we were all mobilised… so when I had a chance to choose what part of the Civil Service I would go into, I chose the Colonial Office.

So you were working in the Civil Service for how long?

Well, for three years… In the Civil Service, in the Colonial Department, all the normal Civil Servants, the regular Civil Servants, had been called up, so the anthropologists were brought into that Department, and Raymond Firth, Audrey Richards, and Bill Stanner…. And that's how I decided to do anthropology. Yeah. It paid off! (LAUGHS) Because life didn't start until I did that, you see.

6. Audrey Richards

(p.18,p.19)

She was rather impressive. She was in her forties, and she had this bright red hair, and a handsome, upright woman, and very forthright in her speech, and very informal in her postures, like an anthropologist would be, you know! (LAUGHS) And she was a very strong personality. Also very generous and warm. And she had parties, and at her parties I met many other anthropologists, but somebody, I think it must have been her, lent me Evans-Pritchard's book on the Nuer, and her own book, on *Land, Life and Diet in Northern Rhodesia*. And I was absolutely thrilled! I absolutely made my life decisions when I read those books, actually.

Audrey Richards – was so much more direct, so much more important, than anything that anybody did sitting on the outside and writing about formal political constitutions. She wrote about these people that she really knew and lived amongst, and their formal arrangements, and their informal arrangements in their lives, and who they married, and what happened when all the men left the village to go to work, and how many were in the village. It was very very marvellous fieldwork, and I thought it would be a very, very proud vocation to be able to follow her. You've never read it, have you? Well, the next one was the Nuer. But Audrey Richards made a very very strong impact. I thought it was an ideal to follow.

7. Anthropology and Economics: Raymond Firth

(p 18)
Raymond Firth let me read *The Tikopia*, which didn't make nearly so much impact on me. He was a bit disappointed that I didn't feel so thrilled.

(p.21)
The general idea, and also his earlier work on kinds of markets, which he was very pleased with, I felt it was too facile really. He found markets working, and he identified markets, but he fought a losing war which he created between so-called "formalists" and the "substantivists", in anthropology, in which he was a formalist, and he wanted to do whatever the economists were doing, as far as he knew it, which was pretty elementary – it was about cost-benefit, price, supply and demand in unmonetarised economies. People did very interesting work on that at that time, but he wasn't in on it, and most of them

were on the substantivist side, against him, and I was torn. I thought we ought to be benefiting from what the economists were doing.

8. Evans Pritchard, Anthropology and Catholicism: Return to Oxford

(pp.22-23)
The War came to an end, and the Education Department announced grants for anybody who could prove that their education was incomplete, which was a problem for me, because I'd done my degree. But somehow I managed to get a grant to go back to Oxford, and I particularly wanted to study with Evans-Pritchard.

This was a reaction against two people, two anthropologists, Raymond Firth and Bill Stanner, who was a good friend of mine, close friend. Both of them said, "You'll never stay [as an] anthropologist, you'll have to give up your religion. There's no way an anthropologist can be a Catholic". Now, the nuns had founded me much too well, intellectually, to know that that could make sense at all. What they were saying was totally superficial, and how much difference can it make to your understanding of your relation with God and institutions that you've been brought up with, to know that other people have had a different idea of God? But they thought it did, you see.

So I was very careful to go to a place where I wouldn't ever be faced with that silly question, and chose to work with Evans-Pritchard, who was known to be a Catholic….And then I really started to live! I wasn't really at all awake anyway, before that, as you can gather.

That's wonderful! So now, you did say, earlier, that reading The Nuer inspired you? Could you say what was that inspiration?

MD: I liked it, yes. Yes. I'd never seen Evans-Pritchard, I'd never read a book like it, and I had a kind of pictorial sense of a very powerful abstract painting rather than a fussy detailed thing. The strong structural lines impressed me enormously, and how he got structure out of the very unpromising means that he had in his fingers, [to show how] the

organisation of their lives, was always organised by principles, very highly principled, so that you'd wonder what they did when they would produce a rule, you know - where the women are the cattle are not, you know! (LAUGHS)

9. Ethnography versus theory

(p.69-70)
We were not allowed to value and to read and to use Leach's best book, which is *Highland Burma*. It's a very great book. But I couldn't find out what was wrong with it. "Why can't we read it?" I asked Godfrey, and it's the same answer as the one about the British Academy. If you remember the book, it starts out saying that, "Ethnography isn't important. What the people actually do, these detailed, descriptive things are not important. What's important is the theory". And E-P just felt sick at that. He thought, "All our students are going to give up doing good ethnography. If they read that, they won't bother with facts, and it's a complete opening of the gates of hell, conversation can be anywhere". This was important to them.

10. Why is there no anthropology of Europe?

(p.46)
I wanted to do Italy. I didn't think of doing Greece. But I felt, as I was born in Italy, it would be a good idea to go back and to study a small Italian village. This is relevant to the History of Anthropology, actually, not to me only, because I got absolutely no encouragement, and I was telling Marco, who's interested in this particular point about academic authority, that they had good reason not to want me to go, because none of them could have supervised. There wasn't anybody there, in the [Oxford] Department, who could have properly supervised a thesis on Mediterranean areas. And, moreover, there wasn't anybody there who could have supervised, not just Italy, but any Mediterranean area….. But Evans-Pritchard and Fortes ran it, and they said, "It has to be Africa. There's no theory developed for the Mediterranean", which meant I would only do some sort of superficial journalistic thing. Even if I had been supervised, there wasn't anything to say about Greek villages. And that has remained the plight of Mediterranean Studies, except for Arab Studies, which are Mediterranean, but they count as Arab.

11. Choosing the Lele

(p.48)

So I went to the Biennial Conference of the IEUS – International Union of Ethnographic Studies. At that place, they said, "Well, you'll find somebody there on the African side, and they'll give you advice and ideas about where to go". I met Georges Brausch, who was a District Officer in the Congo. And they had said the Congo might be a good idea, because nobody English had done it, and if I was going to get money from the International African Institute, it ought to be a non-English colony. So that's why I was expecting to find somewhere in the Congo… I've told you that before. Okay. Well, then Brausch said, "You have to go to the Lele".

12. Preparing for fieldwork

(pp.26-27)

I wanted to do a matrilineal people. If I'd done the Sudan, E-P would have loved me, and looked after me, you see, but I didn't fancy being amongst all those cattle! You know, the women who did, got a lot of help and attention from him. He was really interested in that. He didn't believe in fieldwork methods as a formal thing, he believed much more in interest and personal initiative, so I remember saying to Godfrey – after I was going into the field, and was leaving quite soon, Godfrey Leinhart was a great friend…. "And I haven't got any idea what to do with fieldwork, nobody's ever spoken to me about taking notes or anything". So he said, "Well, what do you want to know?" So I said, "Well, how does one take notes?" So he looked at me, quizzical. So he put his head on one side and looked at me, and thought, "Well, you don't smoke, do you?" "No". He said, "Ah, that's a pity. I always wrote my notes on the back of cigarette cases!" (LAUGHS) So we had no formal training whatsoever

Were you not taught how to interview at all?

No. No. Even the idea of interview is slightly suspect, compared with just being there. Yeah. Participation.

You weren't taught to observe either?

No! Not really! (LAUGHS) I frankly, say, no. No.

And would that be normal in Anthropology Departments at that time?

Yes…We were much amused and slightly bothered by John Barnes's system of taking notes and cross-indexing them on absolutely everything. So you write down … "Tribe. Chiefs. Guns. Chief Lender, guns. Guns, see guns". This was not the kind of attitude we were supposed to take at all!

But why do you think that was so? Was meant to be inspiration which made you understand?

Empathy. And common sense. You had problems, you wanted to know how they lived, what sort of things they minded about. How did they reconcile the contradictions in their lives? It all followed from itself. And we had these marvellous models of Evans-Pritchard's and Meyer Fortes's books, and Audrey Richards.

13. Language for anthropologists

(p.14, pp.11-13)
My father send me out to France for six months, to learn French, and to learn a few things about how women could dress and present themselves. Six months wasn't really very long, and so I did do that, and it made me feel happier with French than I would have otherwise done, so that was very important. I'm really very bad at languages. Mmm.

That's interesting, because I noticed one thing that you said in one of your new prefaces, that if you were to go back to the Congo, you would learn the language better.

Yes. Take it seriously, yes.

Why? You don't think you took it seriously?

No, I didn't know enough about languages, you see….Before I went out, I was sent to some classes that were run in London, on Bantu languages, a little small group of other people were going out to speak a Bantu language, and I was told that the one that I was going to study when I went out there, was similar to the one that we used for our lessons, which was Luba, [but it seemed as close] as German is to Modern Greek! For somebody who has no intellectual appreciation of languages, that just left a great gulf….

There was no dictionary, no grammar, nobody who spoke either English or French, so I was a hopeless person to send there! ..I struggled… Have you ever tried to learn a language that there is absolutely no guidance for whatsoever?

Fortunately, had a very good house servant, who was my cook, as we called him, or my "boy", and he would come with me to any meetings, and then he would tell me afterwards, quietly, slowly, what was going on. And I made enough friends for them to explain to me what was going on….but there was a whole lot happening there I wasn't understanding.

14. Fieldwork: the Lele

(p.33)
I went up the river to the Missionary Society, which was the missionary base, which was in the middle of the Lele area, aimed for the Lele, because I knew that was the place I wanted to go to. The missionaries gave me a kind welcome, and found me a servant, and got me someone to give me language lessons, and I stayed there about two weeks. And then I set off. They organised a lorry for me, from Unilevers. Unilevers ran the place, financially, by having everybody cut down palm trees for palm nuts, for oil. So I and my cook arrived in this village. We collected a friend of his on the way, so I had two servants. And the question was where I would sleep. The first village had a nice rest house, Missionary House, a big open hut made for the missionaries, called a "Rest House", where they stopped. But I didn't stay there very long, because the cook didn't like it. He said, "Let's go to my village". So we went off to his village next time there was a lorry going by, and we were much happier there.

So what kind of house did you have there?

I had a Lele house, like they had, only a bit bigger…. It was made of bamboo, split bamboo, against a structure of their equivalent of wattle. So the cladding was split bamboo, around outside, and inside, it was on a wooden frame. And it had an open door you could go in, and a window, with a shutter, up and down shutters – Venetian blinds sort of thing, made of bamboo – and a table, and a little separate room with a bed and a basin, and I had to have a latrine built for me outside, a bit further out of the village. And the big difference between that hut and their huts was that it had a door, whereas their huts had a teeny little opening that you crawled in and out of, about four foot or three foot off the ground, to keep sorcerers and leopards out. So I was more exposed. Nice hut, I liked it though.

My explanation of my being there was I was there to learn the language. They soon realised that was wrong, because I wasn't learning it enough! But it went for a bit, and then they thought I would stay and write about them, and they would be famous – which was true that I wrote about them, but they're not famous. There are a lot of them here in London…They're having lunch with us on Saturday, yes…

So have you always kept up with the Lele?

As much as I could, yes. Yes.

That's interesting. Do you think that's typical of an anthropologist?

I think so, yes. Yes.

Do you get an emotional attachment to your people?

Oh yes, very strong sense of attachment, yes.

(p.35)
PT: So how do you get to observe?

MD: Oh well, I'd go out with a notebook, and a little stool on my arm, that I can sit down on, and asked them to help learn some grammar, or give me a few words, and then I hear there's a meeting, and I go to it, and I found it very hard, at the beginning, to hear at all what was said, but gradually I got to understand – particularly the women helped me a lot. And I got reproached for talking like a woman! (LAUGHS) They talk quite differently.

(p.36)
They wouldn't let me into the forest, in the first village, because they said that the spirits in the forest wouldn't like me going there, and they, themselves, were terribly careful of taboos in a forest, so if I went, a log would fall on me, or I'd fall on a log and I'd break a leg, and then the government would be on them like a ton of bricks, and they couldn't really risk having me around, unless I stayed in the village – which bored me stiff! I got no exercise, and I couldn't see what was happening. So the cook said, "Come on, we'll go to my village. They'll accept you there, because I'm a son of the village". And that was true. I was able to go into the forest whenever anybody went, and I had a number of women friends who would say, "Come on, we're off. We're going to get some water", and so I'd go with them. And that was delightful. I did lots of things with them.

Did you try hunting, then?

Yes! For a short time! (LAUGHS) Yes! I was really hopeless! I'd never had a gun before! When I went back some ten years later, people I knew were still there, and they said, "Ah! We always remember your hunting. How wonderful you were as a hunter" – politeness again, you see. "We remember all the things you killed. There were five. There was that eagle. There was that hawk. And that guinea fowl. And that monkey that got …" Five things I shot! (LAUGHS) Full of charm. Very very very personal people. Very clever too.

(p. 38: Fieldwork notes)
Now, you went around pretending that you had a language book, but did you actually have a fieldwork notebook?

MD: Yes. Yes. I used to write my notes up in the evenings, and then I would ask them in the morning to fill in - they had "age sets" for instance. I do remember that each of the age sets that divided the village, had a special name. And then there were other age sets that had died out. So I'd go round and say, "I've only got this number, and how many more age sets should I write down?" So I tried to be systematic. And they were happy to tell me, they didn't mind.

So have you kept those notebooks?

Yes, but I'm afraid they're stored in Michigan. They're stored in North-Western.

15. Understanding mental worlds

(p.28)
The big instruction we had, which was not about the mechanism of writing notes, but it was about being a scholar of the area. We were supposed to read everything about that area before we started, and to know all about what had been written before - not on your tribe, your tribe would never have been written about before – mine wasn't, much. But all about the whole of the lower part of the Congo, I was supposed to know. So, therefore, I had a basis for comparison for asking questions… But I liked that advice, that was the kind of advice, you know, it was much more a literary approach.

(p.29, p28)
I wanted to know – what I did find, these metaphysics of foreign people, those wonderful romantic ideas they had. So when I got to the place where they were all talking about animals, I would say, "Why can't women eat this animal?" Or, "Why don't … why doesn't anybody eat it?" or, "Why can only warriors, who have killed a man, eat it?" They'd always start answering me, first of all, "Well, that's what the old people told us", and when I still insisted that wasn't good enough an answer, they said, "Well, have you ever seen it?" So I said, "No". And then they would describe it's life habits, the habits and the look of the animal, the appearance of it. And I realised eventually, not too soon, but within a few months, that they were answering my questions. And if I put all the answers together about all the animals, I could do something systematic about their view

of their universe. And that then became a very exciting pursuit, so I really sort of focused on animals for a long time. I had to get the names of the animals translated, because there weren't many left in the forest, they didn't get them very often. So I'd get their name, and a Luba man would translate it into Luba, and then there was a game warden in the Luba country – a Belgian – who knew what the animal was, from Luba, and then I got it back, so that's how I got it!

I was the first person to do a systematic account of all the animals that they classified, and a classification of the animals. But that was what we had been trained to do, you see. So that would be a system…You soon found that there were ground animals – under the ground – and that these were considered very influenced by the ancestors who were buried under the ground. And then there were animals on the land, and they were forest animals, or bush animals. They'd be carnivorous or herbivorous, or nocturnal or diurnal, water animals, and by that classification, you found that there was a whole picture of the social system. There were sky animals – that was squirrels and birds – and sky animals had no implications for people, but all the land animals, and the burrowing animals, were so classified that you had a projection of the social system on the menu, who could eat what, you see. Pregnant women this, and women wanting to be pregnant that. And it was fascinating, it became a marvellous passion for me to watch it and go on asking, and then to get to know the answers myself as I came across new animals…

There was a lovely antelope, which they called "ibudi", and men couldn't eat it, which was amazing, because men really didn't leave much to the women. "Why not?" "Because it's so beautiful, only the women can eat it". Which fits with the impression I was getting of a people who really appreciated female beauty.

16. The Congo Civil War: from ethnography to philosophy

(p.40)
He's an extraordinary fellow, Ian Gotcray. He's now one of the big directors of one function of UNICEF in New York. But when I was in [America], when he came and he did a Ph.D., in California, we saw each other quite a bit. And on his suggestion… he took me back in '87, to the Lele country, which he called "une visite de nostalgie". He looked after me for six weeks, giving up his leave for that. And was a real close friend to me all

that time, very very careful of me, and looking after me. A fantastic visit I had, thanks to him. A tragic visit though, because they were very poor when I went, they were quite destitute when I went back, and now much worse, with war. It's terrible to think of.

(p.41)
Because of warfare really, yes… because of the lack of paid occupation. It had become a cash economy, but no way of earning cash. They'd forgotten how to make fire, they need matches. Because, in order to keep a non-match household economy going, you need other people with fires, so if yours goes out, you can go and grab a bit of fire somewhere else.

The whole field dried up. At that point, normally in a normal anthropology career, you've done your fieldwork, you've got your degree, you join a teaching Department, and you are teaching students who go out to your area, and you help them, and comment on them, and you build up a general knowledge of the area. But I couldn't do that, and they couldn't.

You couldn't do that, why?

Civil war.

Oh, so if you both know a particular area, and then that becomes a disaster, this is a professional problem as well.

It certainly is, yes. Yes. Minor professional problem, compared with theirs! But I had to take up philosophy, as it were.

17. Marriage and writing: James Douglas

(p.42)
He was Director of the Conservative Research Department eventually, but he called himself a "backroom boy of Conservative Party politics". So he had to be a service, be an information service, political judgement for the Party.

And to what extent has he been an influence on your work?

Very strong, because first of all, I would never have written at all, but for his requirements of punctuality and mealtimes and an orderly life, otherwise I would never have done anything, you know! And he also has very high standards of work. He didn't see why his supper should be late if I wasn't doing well, if I wasn't doing proper work, writing properly!

I think you suggest that his sense of order was one of the reasons why you got interested in [concepts of purity and dirt in relation to housework.]

MD: Yes, that continues, yes.

(p.63)
One thing that interests me is that, you get married, and then you have the children, and then you write about dirt. Now, do you think this is partly because of being involved in keeping a house?

Yeah. Oh well, in a sense, I look back on *Purity and Danger* and think I wrote it because I didn't believe in dirt. That there was too much pressure to keep things clean! And that this was ritual, not meaningless ritual, but ritual that meant something different from looking after bacteria, or preventing them from entering your food, but ritual about occasions and about continual celebrations of different relationships. That was a hierarchical thing.

(pp.62-63)
I didn't have to do a book on economics, but after I'd finished *Purity and Danger*, it seemed that the part that I was weakest on in explaining and understanding, and that there was more to say, was on the economy. I also felt that the anthropologists weren't understanding it enough either, and that we had, as anthropologists, to tell the economists about what he calls my theory of "pocketing". The interest he has in running a budget together, having to share money problems together, he found I had this [theory]. Economists like to think of money as utterly available for all purposes and, therefore, you

rank the purposes. But I found, myself, wanting to have it as a woman who has four jam jars on her mantle-piece – one's for the milkman, and she puts the money in for the milkman when she gets it, and the money for the paper boy, and the money for the grocer, and all her household things are in separate pockets, and then you don't go beyond that pocket for each thing, so that the pockets are more material to you than the actual [overall budget] - they are a way of materialising the expenditures and putting them into groups, and making a budget

18. Anthropology and Motherhood

(p.73)
They can't go on doing fieldwork once they've got a lot of babies. And I went back to the field after I had my first baby, to do more fieldwork, because I'd had my Ph.D., but I was told not to publish it until I'd gone and checked a lot more. So I took a long vac off and left my child and husband with his mother, and I went back for the long vac. And I knew that was the end of fieldwork, whereas a real anthropologist has to go on going back to the field. And also, to extend their field knowledge, they have to go round - so that you're not just a Lele expert, but you're the Congolese expert, you know…. But I obviously couldn't do that kind of career once I had a husband and a first child, a second child and a third child. So it appeared that I would do the things that were coming to hand.

And then there was the trouble in the Congo too.

Exactly. I couldn't get back to the Congo either, no.

19. Power and Being a Woman

(p.85)
Yes, I think it's very personal, yes. Lots of women can organise, and do. Did you see that wonderful programme about on "If …" The "If …" series? It was, "If the world was run by women". They had these high powered women, it was terribly funny and very good! And, certainly, I know lots of women who could have done what I needed to do, but I didn't see it as something I needed to do. I think being an anthropologist really

blocks you from wanting to run/organise things. If I'd been good at administration, for example, some people naturally are, but I'm very bad.

So it's a question of whether you're attracted to that kind of role, really.

Yes. Yes, yes, yes.

20. Natural symbols

(p.75)
I had very strong insistence that classification is an aspect of organising, so if they're organising their lives, they need to classify. They need to classify in order to organise, and so, therefore, you could understand a classification system by looking at the organisation. But I didn't do that for the sake of these animals that were forbidden for food. I thought it was enough that they didn't fit the classification system… You don't bring that animal into this place. You don't have these two animals on the same food together. So by making the separations in your house, and in your manners, and on your table, you're celebrating the big separations of the universe. So that's a much stronger analysis, and I've been plugging that for a long time now. And thinking on those lines, I did a book called, *Natural Symbols*.

(p.78-79)
I think it rang a lot of bells. I think probably there's a connection with Catholicism, surely, which is ritualistic, and doesn't explain much, but just says it, and is very hierarchical, meant to be a hierarchy, and the Nonconformist religions, which go for emotions much more, feelings. It seemed to me to run very deep through all society, and especially through social change, which change is a movement away from whatever the system was before, which generally tends to have grown up [with] a lot of hierarchical structures, whatever it says. And social change means pulling them down, getting rid of them. So I felt it was a tremendously powerful insight that could be applied anywhere, and that's what *Natural Symbols* was about.

21. The World of Goods

(p.81)

Because [they were] a people without money, to whom money was introduced. They had something like an artificial, a "restricted currency" it was called, which was raffia cloth, which they could pay big sums in, like blood money and marriage payments, and they could buy, and they could pay for services with it. And so there's a whole chapter about restricted monies in that book. But most important on that theme is that economists are so narrow in their perception of human behaviour, and they are so materialist, they really think that people want goods to use themselves, so they got an ego buying things for self, whereas people want them, in order to give them away, to control other people. And they're missing out on that, the whole control aspect of satisfaction, control and power, I think.